

Raul Pacheco-Vega, PhD

Understanding and solving intractable resource governance problems.

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Synthesizing different bodies of work in your literature review: The Conceptual Synthesis Excel Dump (CSED) technique

Since I'm writing a series of posts on literature reviews (and undertaking a few of my own), I figured I could expand on how you can combine citation tracing, concept saturation, results' mind-mapping with a method that Professor Elaine Campbell showcases in her excellent post ["How I use Excel to manage my literature review"](#).

I call this technique the **"Conceptual Synthesis Excel dump"** – I call it "dump" because I basically throw into the Excel file everything that is already in my **research** and **conceptual/reflective** memoranda. Doing the conceptual synthesis Excel dump **as you do your reading** allows you to create a nice map of the literature. It also helps reach **conceptual saturation during the literature review**.

What I am showing here is my Excel dump on bottled water. There are a number of themes (if you're doing coding in qualitative methods, you'll understand what I mean) that interest me:

- Fear of the tap water.
- Decisions on whether to consume tap water vs. bottled water.
- Branding water and bottled water and the use of branding techniques in promoting bottled water.
- Ethical bottled water.

I am showing three screen captures of the Excel file I created. Note that the columns I use are the following:

- **Concept** – here I list the main idea or major theme of the specific literature review.
- **Citation** – here I include the full citation (article, book, book chapter).
- **Main idea** – here I summarize the full article in a sentence or two.
- **Notes 1** – here I make notes about specific ideas or whether I agree or disagree
- **Notes 2** – same as the above
- **Notes 3** – same as the above
- **Cross-reference** – which references and citations are linked to one another.
- **Quote/quotation** – specific quotes, as per my memorandum technique, that could be useful
- **Page** – the page from where I drew the quote. Note that I can draw several quotes from same article

Concept	Citation	Main idea	Notes 1	Notes 2	Notes 3	Quote/quotation	Page
Concept 1	Chapman, Steven L. 2009. "Bottled or Tap? A Commentary for Science, Economics, and Society." <i>Social Movements</i> 3(2):20-28	Are the bottled water franchise and trade water for bottled water?	Research and writing	Fear of the tap	Fear of the tap	Subsistence level is controlled so that food is further made to that food in this case? Are the benefits derived from bottled water do health greater than those derived to the food that this are eating the "reference in cost"?	20
Concept 2	Corbett, Peter W. et al. 2011. "Perceptions about water and increased use of bottled water in Mexico/Children: A review of pediatric and adolescent medicine." <i>BMJ</i> 343(7832):e6	Bottled water use and benefits from research	Water franchise and trade water for bottled water	Research and writing	Fear of the tap	Fear of the tap	21
Concept 3	Palmer, David, Linn, Marlene, Ursula, Ursula, and Marlene. 2012. "Tap or Bottled Water: Drinking Preference among Urban University Students and Adolescents." <i>Journal of Community Health</i> 37(2):24-35	Bottled water use and benefits from research	Water franchise and trade water for bottled water	Research and writing	Fear of the tap	Fear of the tap	24
Concept 4	Yoon, Alvaro M., Alvaro, Alvaro, Alvaro, Alvaro, and Alvaro. 2012. "Bottled Water Consumption in Mexico: A Literature Review." <i>Water Resources</i> 46(1):1-10	Bottled water consumption	Water franchise and trade water for bottled water	Research and writing	Fear of the tap	Fear of the tap	1

Concept	Citation	Main idea	Notes 1	Notes 2	Notes 3	Quote/quotation	Page
Concept 1	Perley, Neil. 2011. "Bottled Water: A Review of the Literature." <i>Water Resources</i> 45(1):1-10	Bottled water consumption	Water franchise and trade water for bottled water	Research and writing	Fear of the tap	Fear of the tap	1
Concept 2	Corbett, Peter W. et al. 2011. "Perceptions about water and increased use of bottled water in Mexico/Children: A review of pediatric and adolescent medicine." <i>BMJ</i> 343(7832):e6	Bottled water use and benefits from research	Water franchise and trade water for bottled water	Research and writing	Fear of the tap	Fear of the tap	21
Concept 3	Palmer, David, Linn, Marlene, Ursula, Ursula, and Marlene. 2012. "Tap or Bottled Water: Drinking Preference among Urban University Students and Adolescents." <i>Journal of Community Health</i> 37(2):24-35	Bottled water use and benefits from research	Water franchise and trade water for bottled water	Research and writing	Fear of the tap	Fear of the tap	24
Concept 4	Yoon, Alvaro M., Alvaro, Alvaro, Alvaro, Alvaro, and Alvaro. 2012. "Bottled Water Consumption in Mexico: A Literature Review." <i>Water Resources</i> 46(1):1-10	Bottled water consumption	Water franchise and trade water for bottled water	Research and writing	Fear of the tap	Fear of the tap	1

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About Raul Pacheco-Vega, PhD

I am a Full Professor with the Methods Lab at the Facultad Latinoamericana de Ciencias Sociales (FLACSO) Sede Mexico. My research is interdisciplinary by nature, and I identify both as a political scientist and as a human geographer, the two fields in which I trained during my doctorate. For a long time, my work centered [...]

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- udinslotjago168djarur on How to make your claim of novelty and contributions to the scholarly literature VERY clear with an example

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Source	Main idea	Notes
Wick, Richard. 2008. "Bottled Water: The Pure Connection to the Top of the Food Chain." <i>Journal of Consumer Culture</i> 8(3): 255-25.	Bottling water is a consumer culture phenomenon.	
Wick, Richard and Jeffrey Berman. 2002. "Cults for Ethical Corporate Social Responsibility and the Transformation of Bottled Water into a Consumer Cultural Community." <i>Environment & Society</i> 25(1): 3-15.	Bottling water is a consumer culture phenomenon.	
Geert, Arjo. 2008. "Constructing Purely Bottled Water and the Consumption of Nature." <i>The Journal of American Culture</i> 22(4): 41-16.	Bottling water is a consumer culture phenomenon.	
Jeffrey Berman and Karen Neumann. 2002. "Bottle Water: Ecology, Bottled Water, Commodification, and Consumption." <i>Organization & Environment</i> 35(3): 338-55.	Bottling water is a consumer culture phenomenon.	

My Conceptual Synthesis' Excel dump technique is quite handy in the process of creating a literature review (both to reach concept saturation and to create the mind map). Hopefully it will be helpful to you too! I wrote this post partly as a response to the tweet below 🙏



Not found

Love this – kind of like @raulpacheco's memo-ing, only in spreadsheet form 🙏
<https://t.co/yT9pjaVChx>

— Rebecca Linnett (@rebeccalinnett) June 15, 2016

IMPORTANT EDIT – After many requests, I finally got around creating a **Conceptual Synthesis Excel Dump template** that you can download and edit for your own purposes. I use a framing theory paper but you can adapt to your needs.

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Posted in academia, research.

Tagged with literature review, research, writing.

By Raul Pacheco-Vega – June 17, 2016

rev="post-2225" 6 comments

6 Responses

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Annabell Hazelton says

In Excel, I actually am going to attempt to color code all of this so my neurodivergent brain can make sense of it instead of just seeing words and boxes! That way I can read across better. This helps me a great deal as an assistant.

April 28, 2022, 2:07 pm



Nass says

Thanks a lot !

September 3, 2022, 7:53 am

Continuing the Discussion

Using Overview Devices in scholarly research and academic writing – Raul Pacheco-Vega, PhD [linked to this post on August 6, 2019](#)
 [...] Conceptual Synthesis Excel Dump (CSED) – gives you an overview of the material you have read for your literature [...]

Writing a literature review assignment (and for instructors: providing guidance) – Raul Pacheco-Vega, PhD [linked to this post on August 10, 2019](#)
 [...] a Conceptual Synthesis Excel Dump [...]

Making your research "dialogue" with other scholars' in your literature review – Raul Pacheco-Vega, PhD [linked to this post on November 30, 2019](#)
 [...] idea with that of other scholars you need to know what they said and where. This is why the Conceptual Synthesis Excel Dump (CSED) is important: you can search the Excel file for a particular idea or concept that may seem relevant [...]

Reading techniques for undergraduate students, a primer: Learn how to write arguments first, then how to read in depth, then how to skim – Raul Pacheco-Vega, PhD [linked to this post on May 1, 2020](#)
 [...] may need in my class. I show them how to write synthetic notes, how to write memorandums, how to synthesize their research in an Excel dump and a whole lot of reading strategies, literature review writing processes and note-taking [...]